

YOU'VE EARNED THE RIGHT TO MOVE FAST.

The buyer, the workaround, and real commitment are all in place. What usually stands between here and a raise isn't more evidence — it's the room, and the story that gets you in it.

VENTURE SIGNAL Investor-Ready Signal	BUILD STATUS Working product
---	---

YOUR SINGLE HIGHEST-LEVERAGE MOVE

Turn your **strongest proof point** into a pitch that survives real investor questions.

WHAT YOU TOLD US

Customer conversations so far	15 or more
Can you name the exact buyer?	Yes — I can describe their role and their day
What they do about it today	I've seen or heard it firsthand
Real commitment shown	Yes — money, a signature, or scheduled time
How much is built	A working product or prototype
Business entity	Yes — a different entity (C-corp, partnership, etc.)

WHY THIS IS THE MOVE

What opens doors from here isn't a bigger product — it's credibility that compounds: for funding, for partnerships, for the next hire who's trusting you with their own career. That's the part of "investor-ready" that's easy to miss.

As a technical founder, this usually isn't a build problem — it's a proof problem. The instinct is to keep shipping; the credibility investors and customers actually check for is whether anyone asked for it first.

The evidence is there. What decides the room now is whether your answers hold up when someone pushes on them — and whether each one traces to something checkable.

THE QUESTIONS THAT GET ASKED ONCE THE STORY IS GOOD

1. How many of those customer conversations did you run yourself?
2. What are people doing today instead, and what does that cost them?
3. Who has paid, signed, or scheduled time — and what exactly did they commit to?
4. What did you believe six months ago that you no longer believe?
5. What would make you walk away from this?
6. What are the unit economics at your current price — not at scale?
7. Who is the exact buyer, and who else has to say yes before money moves?
8. What have you tried that didn't work?
9. Why are you the right person for this specific problem?
0. If this works, what breaks first?

WHERE THESE ANSWERS USUALLY FAIL

- An answer with no proof behind it is a story. Every one above should trace to something a stranger could check.
- Numbers at scale standing in for numbers today.
- Naming a market instead of naming a buyer.
- No real answer to #5 — if nothing would change your mind, you're defending a position rather than testing a business.

ANSWER AND PROOF

Q #	YOUR ANSWER IN ONE SENTENCE	THE PROOF BEHIND IT

Run this out loud with someone who has no stake in your success. The gaps tend to show up in the pause before you answer, not on the page.

These are the signals investors, partners, and serious customers tend to check — at any stage, in any industry. None of them are OM's invention, and none of them require anyone's permission to start working on. Here's where your own answers put you today.

SIGNAL	WHAT IT MEANS IN PRACTICE	WHERE YOU ARE TODAY
Customer evidence	Conversations with real potential buyers about what they actually did — not what they say they might do.	IN PLACE
A named buyer	A specific role you can describe, including how their day works — not a demographic or a market segment.	IN PLACE
The current workaround	What people do about this today, seen or heard firsthand. It's what you're really competing against.	IN PLACE
Real commitment	Money, a signature, access, or scheduled time. Verbal interest is common; committed action is rare and it's what gets remembered.	IN PLACE
Build maturity <i>tracked separately</i>	How much exists today. Deliberately kept apart from the signals above — a working product doesn't substitute for proof someone wants it, and having nothing built doesn't count against you.	WORKING PRODUCT

ONE WE DIDN'T ASK — BUT YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO ANSWER

What would make you walk away from this idea? Being able to name the evidence that would change your mind is, on its own, a strong signal to anyone evaluating you: it shows you're testing a belief rather than defending one. Worth writing down before your next conversation.

IF IT'D HELP TO TALK IT THROUGH

If you'd rather not do this part alone, **Session 6 — 7 · Phase 03: Traction & Launch** of Builder 1.0 is built around this exact move. But nothing on the previous page requires a program, or us — start there either way.

Book a 20-minute conversation: opportunitymachine.org
Call: (337) 769-4085 · **Email:** info@opportunitymachine.org
The Acadiana Founder Brief: one email a month, unsubscribe anytime.